
CHURN IS DEAD

The Courage Ladder Audit

A diagnostic tool for CS teams

Measure whether your team optimizes for customer comfort or customer outcomes. Rate your last 10 customer interactions.

Scoring: Rate each item 1-5. 1 = never happens, 5 = standard practice.

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Source: churnisdead.com

Version: 1.0 -- May 2026

SECTION 1

Truth-Telling: Share usage reality vs. stated goals

Customers can't fix problems they don't acknowledge. Truth-telling establishes CS as a credible advisor, not an excuse-maker.

Criteria	What Good Looks Like	What Bad Looks Like
Present data without softening	"Your team logged in 12 times. Your plan assumed 200+. At this pace, you'll miss targets by 60%."	"Adoption has been slower than projected, but that's normal."
Share negative metrics promptly	Dashboard shows concerning patterns within 48 hours of data availability	Wait for customer to ask about problems or discover them independently
Use specific numbers	"8-day approval process vs. 2-day goal"	"Some opportunities to optimize workflow"
Avoid qualifying language	"Your usage is 40% below plan"	"Usage has been a bit lower than we initially hoped"

Score This Section

Criteria	Score
We share negative data without cushioning the impact	1-5
We present gaps using specific metrics and timelines	1-5
We avoid softening language when delivering bad news	1-5

Your Score: ____ / 5

SECTION 2

Gap-Naming: Identify difference between current state and success

Clear problem definition drives solution urgency. Vague problems get vague attention.

Criteria	What Good Looks Like	What Bad Looks Like
Quantify the performance gap	"2-day cycle time goal vs. 10-day reality = 80% efficiency loss"	"Cycle times could be optimized"
Name root causes directly	"Manual approval step adds 8 days"	"Process inefficiencies exist"
Connect gaps to business impact	"At current pace, you'll miss Q1 savings target by \$200K"	"This might impact your goals"
Resist immediate solution-offering	"Here's the gap. What's your plan?"	"Here's the gap, but don't worry, we can fix it"

Score This Section

Criteria	Score
We quantify performance gaps with specific measurements	1-5
We identify root causes without immediately offering solutions	1-5
We connect current-state gaps to business impact	1-5

Your Score: ____ / 5

SECTION 3

Investment-Challenging: Question approach vs. ambition alignment

Misaligned investment expectations doom implementations. Better to reset expectations than manage failure.

Criteria	What Good Looks Like	What Bad Looks Like
Question resource allocation	"You want \$500K savings but assigned one part-time person. What are you optimizing for?"	"What additional resources might help?"
Challenge timeline assumptions	"Comparable companies need 90 days. You've allocated 30. Which assumption is wrong?"	"We'll work with whatever timeline you prefer"
Surface competing priorities	"Your team has 3 other major initiatives. When does this become #1?"	"We understand you're busy"
Force commitment decisions	"Are you committed to the original outcomes or should we redesign?"	"We want to ensure you get maximum value"

Score This Section

Criteria	Score
We question whether resource allocation matches stated goals	1-5
We challenge unrealistic timelines before they become failures	1-5
We force explicit prioritization decisions	1-5

Your Score: ____ / 5

SECTION 4

Future-Forcing: Make them choose between change and consequences

Clarity about consequences drives decision urgency. Ambiguous futures enable procrastination.

Criteria	What Good Looks Like	What Bad Looks Like
Present binary choices	"Change usage patterns or document why this approach failed"	"Let's keep monitoring the situation"
Connect current path to renewal risk	"At this ROI, your CFO won't approve renewal"	"We're here to support whatever you decide"
Set decision deadlines	"We need commitment by Friday or timeline reset"	"Take whatever time you need"
Avoid managing emotional responses	"Here are the consequences of current trajectory"	"Don't worry, we'll figure something out"

Score This Section

Criteria	Score
We present clear binary choices with consequences	1-5
We connect current performance to renewal decisions	1-5
We set specific deadlines for critical decisions	1-5

Your Score: ____ / 5

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Your Scorecard

Dimension	Your Score	Max
1. Truth-Telling: Share usage reality vs. stated goals	_____	5
2. Gap-Naming: Identify difference between current state and success	_____	5
3. Investment-Challenging: Question approach vs. ambition alignment	_____	5
4. Future-Forcing: Make them choose between change and consequences	_____	5
TOTAL	_____	20

Total Score	Assessment	What It Means
16-20	Uncuttable	Embedded, measurable, strategically irreplaceable.
12-15	Defensible	Solid but gaps remain. Focus on lowest dimension.
8-11	Vulnerable	Real risk ahead. Treat as urgent.
4-7	Critical	Cannot survive scrutiny. Major changes needed.

What to do next: Take your lowest-scoring section and build a 30-day action plan. One at a time. Then share this with leadership -- not to ask permission, but to show you know where the gaps are.

Customers don't need another vendor who makes them feel better about their problems. They need advisors who help them solve their problems.

-- Kuber

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